

Table of Strain

A Video-Art Interpretation of Rational Choice Theory

Media Studies & Journalism — University of Liberal Arts Bangladesh (ULAB)

Curriculum Integration (CI) Theme

The Media Studies and Journalism Department of the University of Liberal Arts Bangladesh (ULAB) organizes Curriculum Integration (CI) every semester to encourage students to apply theoretical knowledge through creative and practical work. Instead of learning theories only through textbooks and classroom discussions, CI provides students with an opportunity to interpret those theories through different forms of visual and artistic expression.

The theme of our CI project was Rational Choice Theory. Rational Choice Theory suggests that individuals make decisions by considering the possible benefits, costs, risks and consequences associated with different choices. In other words, people often evaluate the alternatives available to them before deciding what action they should take.

For my video art, titled “Table of Strain,” I tried to interpret Rational Choice Theory from a more personal and emotional perspective. Rather than presenting the theory in a direct or literal way, I wanted to explore the tension that exists before making a choice. The video focuses on hands interacting with objects on a table, fragmented materials and floral elements, creating a sense of repetition, uncertainty and emotional pressure.

The title “Table of Strain” represents the space where choices, pressure and consequences come together. The table becomes a metaphorical space where different possibilities are placed in front of an individual, while the strain represents the emotional and psychological pressure involved in making a decision.

Our Message

Although the video was an individual project, my main message was that every choice carries a cost, and rational decision-making often takes place under pressure.

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In everyday life, people are constantly required to make choices. Sometimes the decision seems simple, while at other times every available option has a consequence. A person may choose something because

it provides immediate comfort, while another choice may provide a better outcome in the long term but require sacrifice.

Through “Table of Strain,” I wanted to represent this internal tension rather than simply explain the definition of Rational Choice Theory. The hands in the video repeatedly interact with the objects on the table, suggesting the process of examining, arranging, changing and reconsidering different possibilities.

The fragmented pieces also represent how a decision can become complicated when there are too many factors involved. A person may try to organize everything before making a final choice, but emotions, circumstances and uncertainty can make the process difficult.

For me, rational choice does not necessarily mean that people make completely emotionless decisions. Instead, it shows how people attempt to find the most suitable option within the circumstances they are facing. The “strain” in the title represents that pressure.

Concept and Visual Layout

The most important visual decision I made was to present the action through a circular, tunnel-like frame. Rather than showing the entire environment, the camera focuses on a limited circular area where the action takes place. This creates the feeling of observing a private or confined space.

I intentionally kept the surrounding area dark. The darkness creates a sense of isolation and allows the circular space to become the main focus of the video. It also represents the uncertainty surrounding a decision. When someone has to make an important choice, they may feel as though they are focusing only on the limited options immediately in front of them.

The table is filled with different visual elements, including flowers and fragmented pieces of material. The contrast between the delicate floral imagery and the torn or disorganized materials creates a tension between beauty and disorder.

The hands are another central element of the video. They repeatedly enter the frame, touch, move and rearrange the objects. I used the hands because they represent human agency. The objects may be placed in front of us, but ultimately it is the individual who has to decide what to do with them.

Toward the end of the video, the lighting becomes more intense and reddish. This change creates a stronger emotional atmosphere and suggests that the pressure surrounding the decision has increased. The final sequence therefore feels more intense than the earlier sections of the video.

Video Making and Production

Creating the video was different from creating a traditional visual artwork because I had to think about movement, time, framing, lighting and sequencing rather than only focusing on a static composition.

At the beginning, I established the title “Table of Strain” before moving into the main visual sequence. I then used the circular framing to gradually introduce the viewer to the table and the activities taking place within it.

One of the challenges was maintaining the visual focus within such a limited frame. Since most of the action happens inside a circular area, the placement of the hands and objects had to be carefully considered. I also had to think about how the viewer would interpret repeated movements rather than simply showing a single action.

Lighting was another important part of the production. The darker surroundings helped create the enclosed atmosphere, while the brighter and redder lighting toward the end added tension to the final part of the video.

The production process taught me that video art requires a different kind of planning. Even a simple movement can become meaningful when it is repeated, slowed down or placed within a particular visual environment.

Reflection on Rational Choice Theory

Working on this project helped me understand Rational Choice Theory beyond its academic definition. Before working on the video, I mainly understood rational choice as a process in which people compare benefits and costs before making decisions. However, while developing the concept, I realized that decision-making can also involve uncertainty, pressure and emotional strain.

The objects on the table can be understood as different possibilities available to an individual. The hands represent the person who has to interact with those possibilities. Moving one object, removing another or rearranging several objects can be interpreted as the process of evaluating alternatives.

The video does not show a clear “right” or “wrong” choice. This was intentional. In real life, people often have to choose between alternatives where none of the options are perfect. The rational decision may simply be the option that seems most beneficial or least harmful under the circumstances.

Therefore, the “strain” in the title is important. Rational decision-making can be difficult because choices have consequences. The more significant the decision, the greater the pressure can become.

Feedback and Response

The process of showing the video and discussing the concept helped me understand how an audience interprets abstract visual work. Because the video does not directly explain Rational Choice Theory, viewers have to interpret the symbols, movements and atmosphere themselves.

This made me realize that visual communication can be powerful, but it also needs enough contextual clarity for the intended message to reach the audience. The title played an important role in guiding the interpretation of the video. Once the idea of “strain” was established, the repetitive movements and confined visual space could be understood as representations of pressure and decision-making.

The project also made me realize that different viewers may interpret the same visual element differently. This is not necessarily a weakness of visual art. Instead, it demonstrates that art can encourage audiences to think and develop their own interpretations.

Realization

The biggest realization I had from this project was that a theory does not always need to be represented literally. Rational Choice Theory is an academic concept, but it can be transformed into an emotional and visual experience.

While making “Table of Strain,” I learned how everyday actions can become symbolic. A hand moving an object can represent a choice. A collection of objects can represent alternatives. A confined frame can represent limitation, while changing light can represent the growing pressure associated with a decision.

I also realized that the process of making video art requires patience. A visual idea that looks simple in the planning stage can become complicated during production. Camera positioning, lighting, timing and movement all have to work together.

If I were given the opportunity to remake the video, I would spend more time experimenting with camera movements, transitions and sound. I would also develop the narrative progression more strongly so that the emotional tension gradually builds from the beginning to the end.

Individual Contribution

Since “Table of Strain” was my individual video art project, I was responsible for the conceptualization, visual planning, arrangement, filming and overall presentation of the work.

I developed the idea of representing Rational Choice Theory through a confined visual space and the repeated interaction of hands with objects on the table. I selected and arranged the visual elements according to the concept and experimented with lighting to create the desired atmosphere.

I was also responsible for operating the camera and deciding the framing, sequence and duration of the shots. During the editing process, I arranged the footage so that the video gradually moved from a relatively calm beginning toward a more intense ending.

Working individually gave me complete creative control, but it also meant that I had to manage every stage of the production myself. This was challenging at times, but it also allowed me to understand my own creative process better.

Photograph / Video

The video art is titled “Table of Strain” and was created as an interpretation of the CI theme, Rational Choice Theory. The video uses a confined circular frame, hands, objects, floral imagery, fragmented materials and changing light to represent the pressure and uncertainty involved in human decision-making.

Conclusion

The CI project provided me with an opportunity to understand Rational Choice Theory through a medium that was very different from conventional academic work. Through “Table of Strain,” I tried to represent the process of decision-making as something that can involve pressure, uncertainty and emotional strain.

The table represents the space where different possibilities exist, while the hands represent human agency and the ability to make choices. The fragmented materials suggest complexity and disorder, while the floral elements introduce a contrasting sense of delicacy and beauty. The dark circular surroundings create a confined atmosphere, and the increasing red light toward the end reflects the growing intensity of the situation.

Most importantly, this project taught me that rational choice is not simply about selecting an option after calculating its benefits. Human decisions take place within real circumstances, where individuals must deal with pressure, limitations and consequences.

Overall, “Table of Strain” was a valuable creative and learning experience for me. It helped me transform an abstract theoretical concept into a visual narrative and strengthened my understanding of video art, visual symbolism, framing, lighting and storytelling. The project also made me reflect on how every decision, no matter how ordinary it may appear, involves a process of choosing, evaluating and dealing with its consequences.